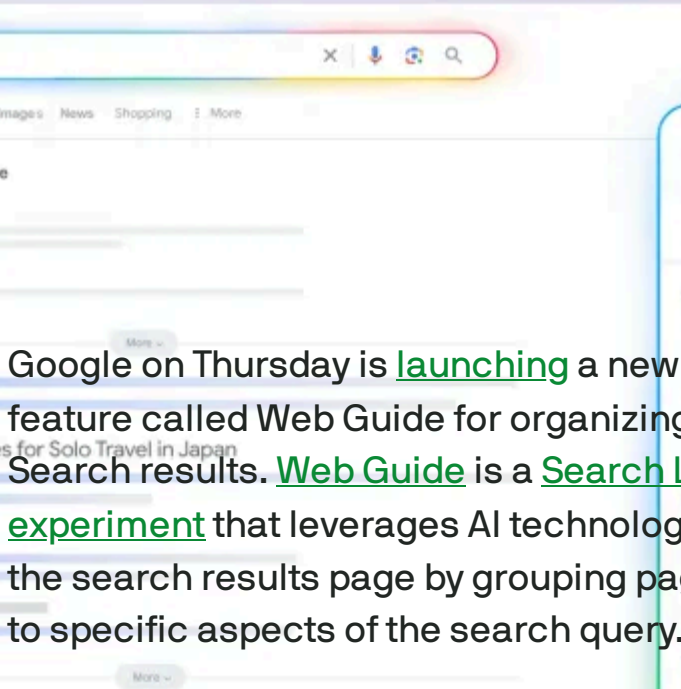


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AI



Google's new Web Guide
search experiment
organizes results with AI



Google on Thursday is [launching](#) a new AI-powered feature called Web Guide for organizing Google Search results. [Web Guide](#) is a [Search Labs experiment](#) that leverages AI technology to organize the search results page by grouping pages related to specific aspects of the search query.

Search Labs experiments are a way for Google to test out new ideas by letting users opt in to those they find interesting. The experiments can be turned on or off at any time and include things like Google's AI Mode, Notebook LM, filmmaking tool Flow, and other, more niche ideas, like an audio show based on news from your Google Discover feed.

IMAGE CREDITS: GOOGLE

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The new [Web Guide](#) experiment is a variation on the fan-out technique for displaying search results that Google is already using with its AI Mode. The feature itself is powered by Gemini, which helps Google better understand the search query and then link to other pages that could have been missed if using a traditional Google Search.

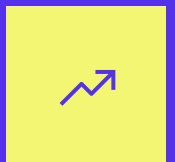
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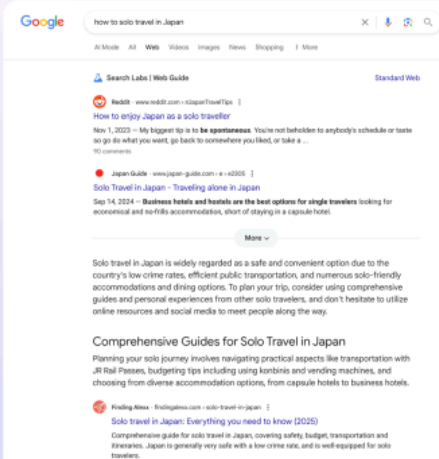


IMAGE CREDITS :GOOGLE

Google suggests the feature works well for open-ended search queries, like “how to solo travel in Japan” or even more complex, multi-sentence queries. For instance, you could ask something like “My family is spread across multiple time zones. What are the best tools for staying connected and maintaining close relationships despite the distance?”

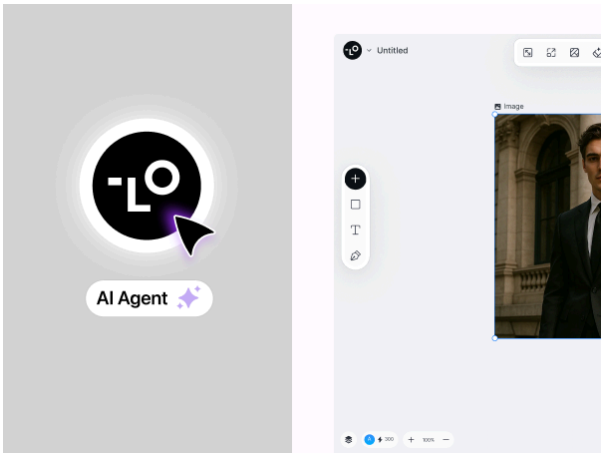
Each section of the search results will focus on one type of answer to the query. With the solo travel example, Web Guide would display groupings like those focused on comprehensive guides, safety tips, links where people have shared their personal experiences, and more.

The experiment will be available to those who opt in and will initially reconfigure the search results on the Web tab on Search. You can also turn off this Web View from this tab itself, if you want to see the standard results without having to disable the experiment entirely.

Over time, Google says the experiment will expand to other areas of Search, too, including the “All” tab.

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Google overhauls Search with tools to follow interests, annotate web pages and more

Sarah Perez — 7:00 AM PST · November 15, 2023

There have been a growing number of complaints that Google Search is not as useful as it used to be. In fact, Google execs even admitted that young people are [turning to services like TikTok and Instagram for their search needs](#), or [are appending terms like “Reddit” to the end of queries](#) to get more useful results. Today, the company is finally ready to do something about this problem with the [launch](#) of two new initiatives. One will see Google

personalizing search results for users by allowing them to “follow” topics of interest in addition to surfacing web pages in new ways. Another, more experimental initiative, will turn Google into a collaborative space where users can annotate web pages with their own notes, which are browsable by anyone else on the web.

The moderation headache that one will bring on is hard to imagine, but Google seems to think it will have it under control.

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IMAGE CREDITS: GOOGLE

The company explains that it will introduce an opt-in experimental feature in Search Labs that will allow web users in the U.S. and India to add a note to almost any web page which will augment search results with users' personal experiences and insights. The idea, on its face, sounds a lot like Google is trying to build a version of Reddit on top of Google itself — a move that would allow it to potentially index more human-generated content [as Reddit locks down its site to avoid becoming fodder for training AI systems.](#)

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IMAGE CREDITS: GOOGLE

Google says some websites won't offer notes, like those focused on sensitive queries or where reliable information is critical. In addition, it says that every note will go through a classification system that will attempt to determine if the note has content that may violate Google's policies. If so, it will then flag that note for human review before it's published live. Users can also report notes for review and when notes are removed, authors can request an appeal if they believe it was pulled by mistake.

All notes and profiles must also meet Google's Community Guidelines, which define the types of

content and behavior that are not allowed, such as child safety, dangerous content, hate speech and spam, among other things, the company says. Webmasters will not be able to opt out of Notes for now.

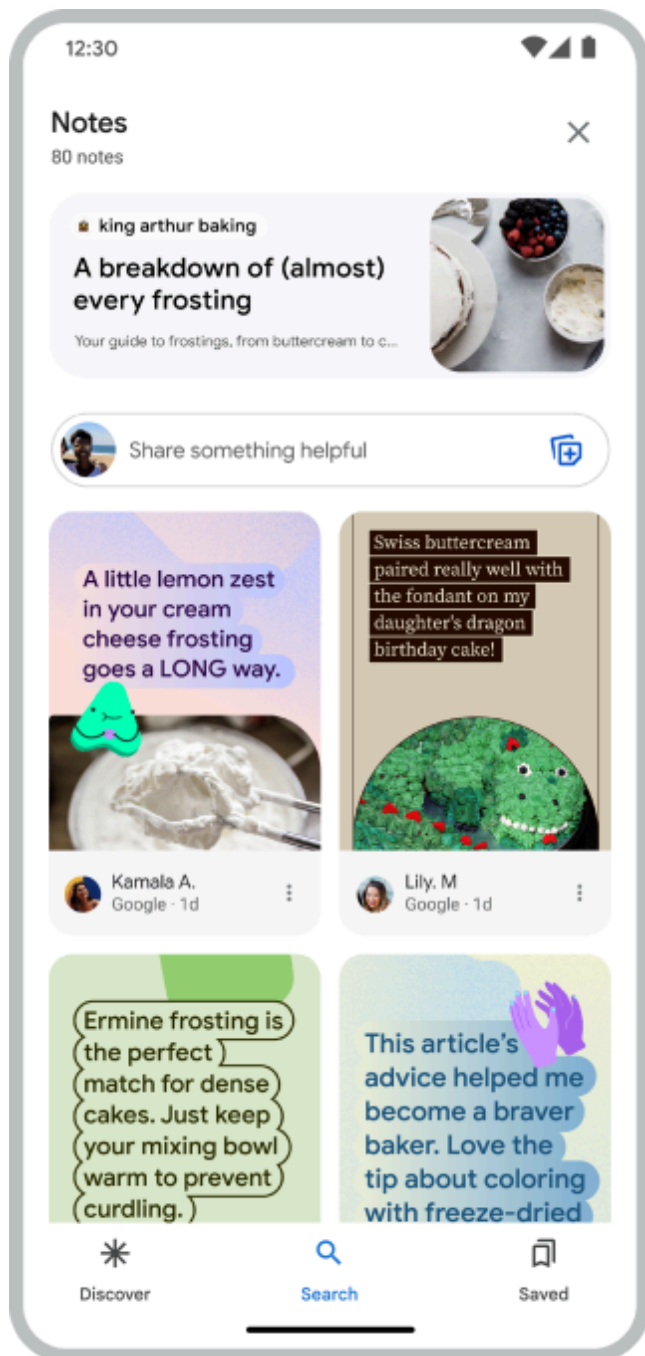


IMAGE CREDITS: GOOGLE NOTES FEED

Web users will be able to browse through others' notes attached to a site through a notes feed, where the most helpful and relevant notes will be surfaced at the top. Unlike Reddit, which is primarily a text-based forum, these notes can also be visual and engaging, Google says. Users will be able to adorn their notes with stickers, images and different visual styles Google imagines use cases for notes that include things like adding tips about improving a

recipe you found, or suggestions of what places to explore when traveling, among other things.

Importantly, the notes will live on the open web, meaning they're indexed by Google's systems. Over time, if the project is successful, it's possible the notes could influence Google's algorithm as well.



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IMAGE CREDITS: GOOGLE

“In the days of the early web, links, and how they were treated by search engines like Google, were really foundational to helping people share their perspectives on content on the web,” explains Brad Kellett, senior director of Engineering for Search.

“This experiment draws on the premise we’ve seen of people really wanting peer validation and to see what others are saying about a given page. With Notes, we’re exploring giving people a new way to share tips and advice about web content, right on Search — helping people answer their most specialized questions, and discover what’s most useful for them on the web,” he says.

Another change is less radical but is launching publicly, not as an experimental feature.

It will allow users to follow topics of interest by tapping a new “Follow” button found in the search results for a given query. By following a topic, users will be alerted to new and timely information about that query as it comes out. This may sound similar to [the age-old Google Alerts system](#) that sends

comprehensive email updates with links to web pages that reference a specific keyword, search term or phrase, but the new “Follow” feature is offering a more curated experience — similar to apps like [Flipboard](#) or [Artifact](#), which offer personalized views into topics of interest.

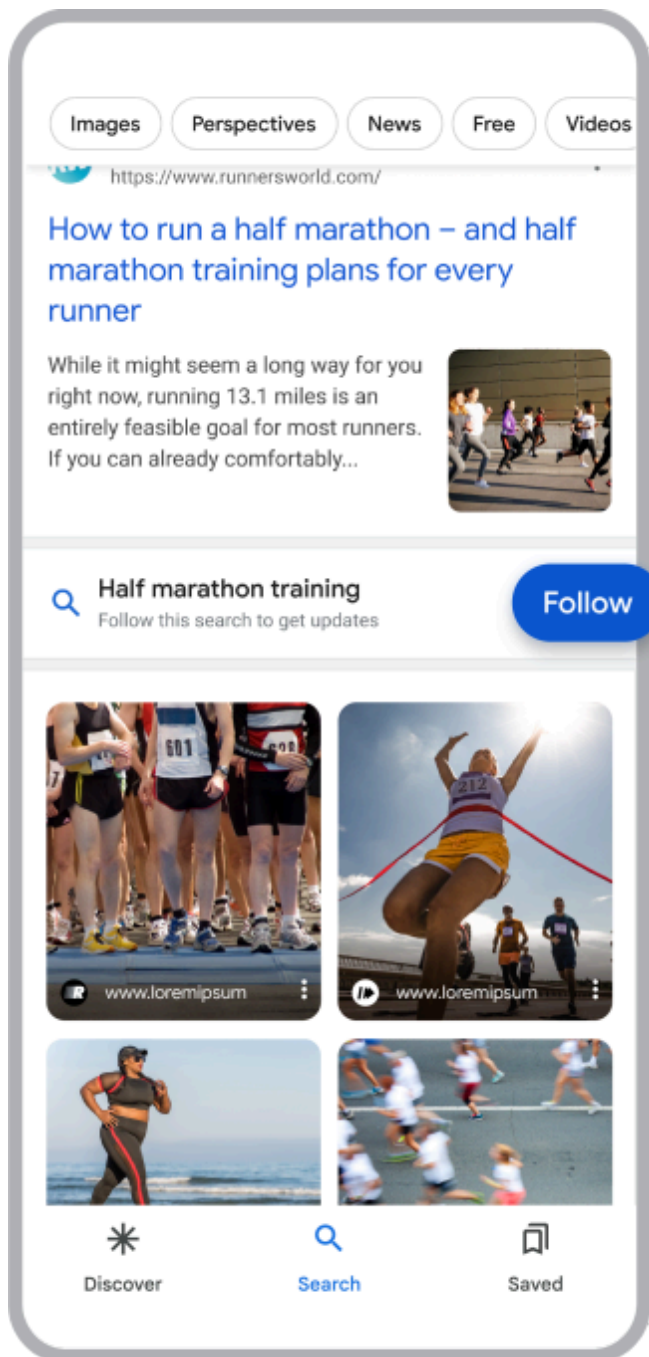
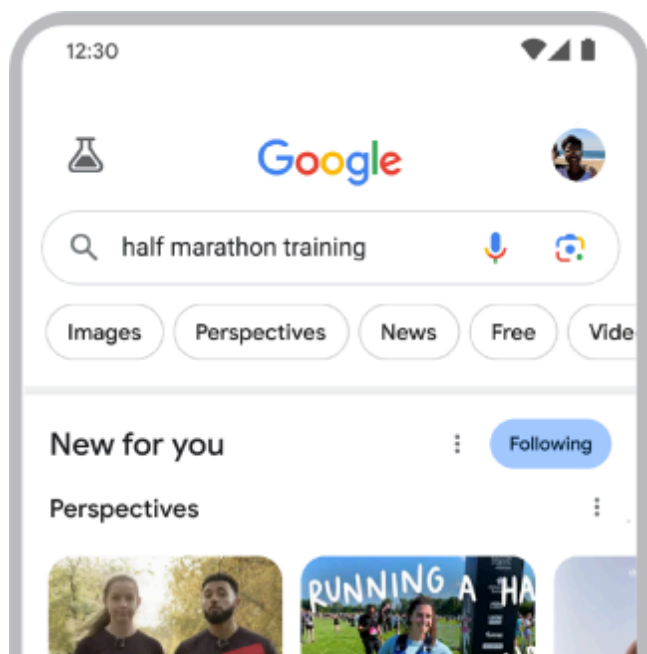


IMAGE CREDITS: GOOGLE

Instead of alerting the user to anything that matches the term, Google will instead surface undiscovered and new content for you on the topic both in its search results (within dedicated modules) and through the Google Discover feature — the homepage in its Google app which offers a personalized news feed.

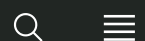
The idea here is that web users will be able to directly signal to Google more about their interests and Google will then deliver them the search results they want, without requiring them to append words like “reddit” to their search queries in order to get personal viewpoints, alongside news and information. It will also allow Google to compile data about users and their interests in the era [where third-party cookies are being deprecated](#) in favor of more privacy-focused systems.

The content that’s surfaced in Follow, meanwhile, will be clearly labeled so as not to be confused with organic results, and all the updates it serves will match [Google’s existing policies for Discover](#).



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Follow will launch on the Google app on Android and iOS and on the Chrome and Safari browsers on mobile devices.

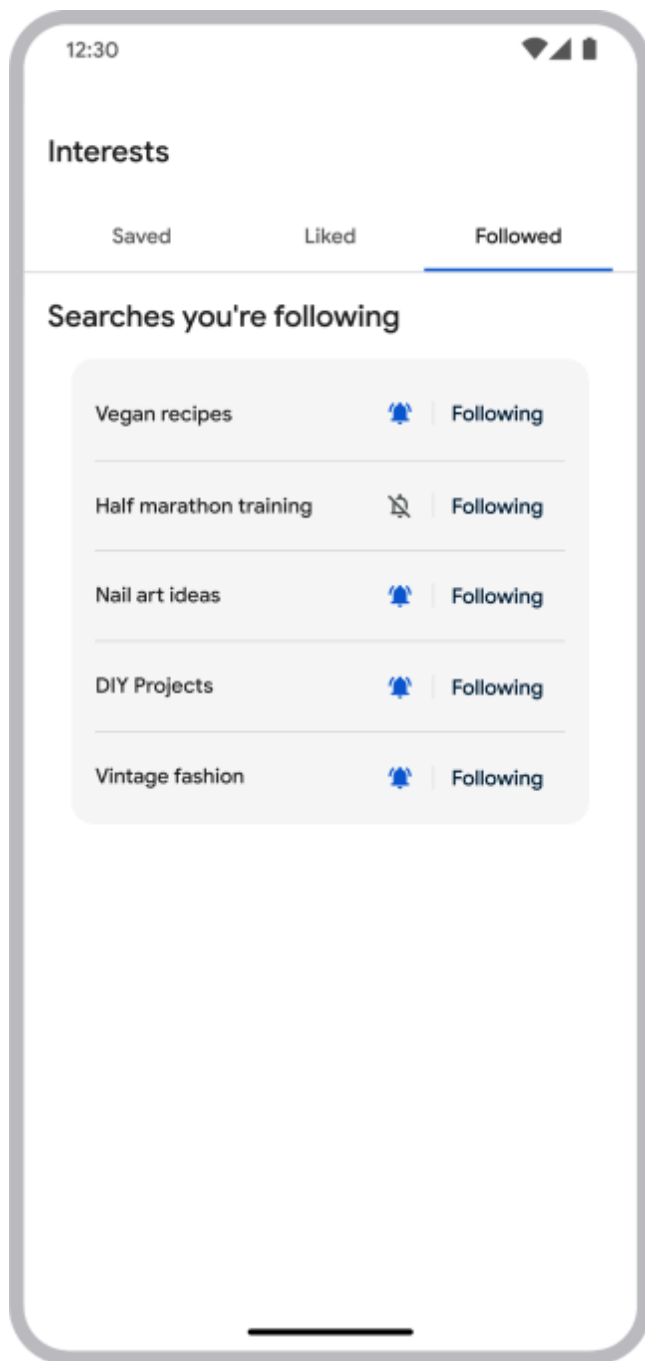


IMAGE CREDITS: GOOGLE

Google says that 15% of the queries it sees every day are totally new, which is one reason why it wanted to offer a more tailored experience to users. But there are also topics of interest that users search for repeatedly, as they seek out the latest information.

As part of these changes, Google will now allow desktop users to filter for different perspectives that may come from forum sites like Reddit and social media sites like YouTube and TikTok. [This feature](#)

was launched on mobile in May, and will include information about the creator, like their social media handle, follower count and the popularity of their content.

Google also rolled out ranking improvements that will push more of these first-person perspectives higher in search results, so they're easier to find.

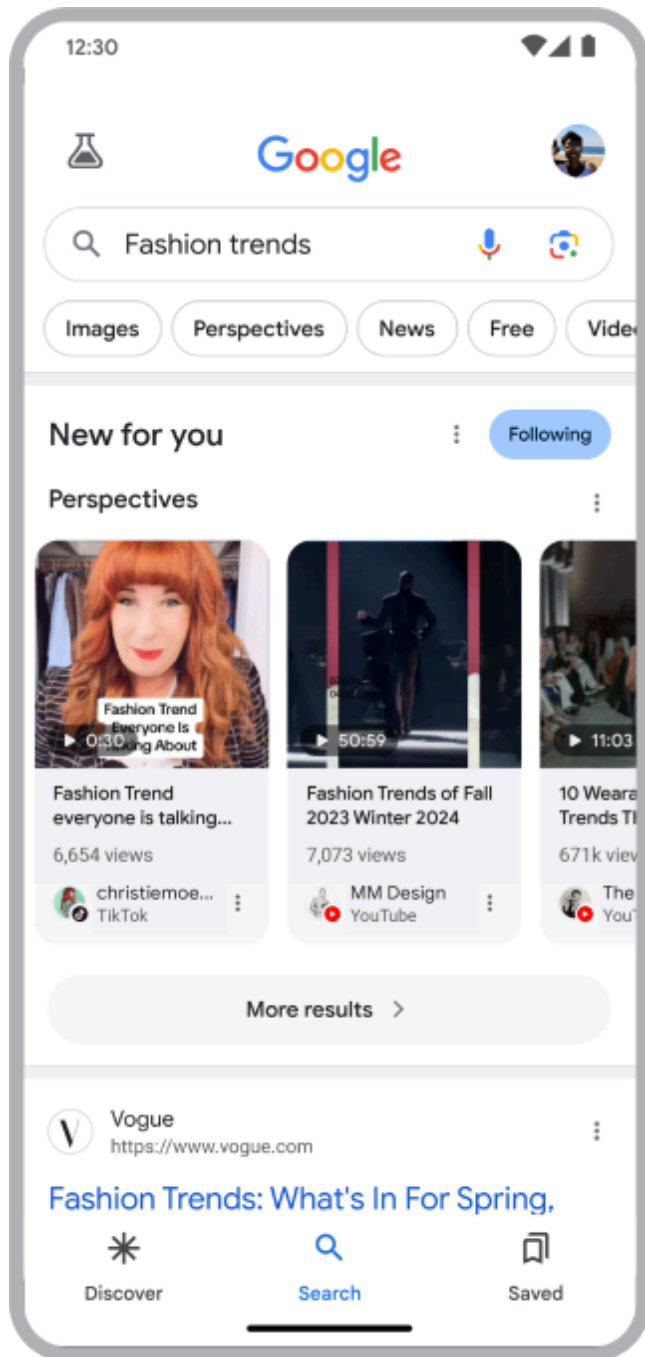


IMAGE CREDITS: GOOGLE

Google's changes follow a chorus of complaints about how SEO-optimized and commercial content has destroyed the web and reduced Google's quality — an issue that came to a head recently after The Verge reported on the people behind the SEO

industry, calling them the “[people who ruined the internet](#).”

SEO professionals pushed back on the report, [calling it bitter and cynical](#), but The Verge was not the first nor the only outlet to comment on the declining relevance of Google Search results in recent years. [The Atlantic](#), for example, dubbed Google Search “bloated and overmonetized,” a modern web where it’s “harder now to find answers that feel authoritative or uncompromised.” Ben Thompson of Stratechery [also brought up the issue in 2019](#), commenting on how many screens users now have to scroll through to get to organic search results, and how [Amazon was eating Google’s lunch on product search results](#) because it simply offered a better consumer experience. [The New Yorker also lamented in 2022](#) that searching Google today led to an experience of being “awash in information and yet compelled by none of it.”

It remains to be seen whether Google’s experiments around highlighting users’ interests and perspectives from other sources beyond standard websites, or the addition of user-generated content, will actually make Google more useful in the long run. It may be that a new era of search is upon us — one that’s AI-led, not a list of links. Google is tentatively embracing this concept too with [its Search Generative Experience that puts an AI chatbot in Google Search](#), but that’s still a Google Labs test for now. In the meantime, it’s working to improve the default search experience for the way people want to consume information — tailored to them, curated and opinionated.

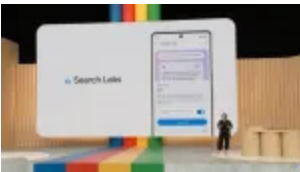
Google ‘Perspectives’ integrates Reddit, YouTube, TikTok and more in search results



Alongside its work to integrate more AI features into Search, Google today also announced it’s introducing a new “Perspectives” filter will be coming to the top of some of its Search results when

the results “would benefit from others’ experiences,” Google says — like posts on discussion boards, Q&A sites and social media platforms including [Continue reading](#)

Google’s AI-powered search experience expands globally to 120+ countries and territories



Google’s AI-powered search experience is rolling out worldwide, after initial launches in select markets, including the U.S., India and Japan. Starting today, the AI-based conversational experience

known as SGE, or Search Generative Experience, will be available in mor than 120 new countries and territories, globally. It will also support four new languages: Spanish

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Google's new tools help discussion forums and social media platforms rank higher in search results

Sarah Perez — 1:09 PM PST · November 27, 2023

Google today [introduced](#) new tools for website owners, including those running social media sites and discussion forums, who want to better elevate their content in Google's search results. The feature follows Google's reprioritization of user-generated web content over SEO-optimized junk, which has [increasingly](#) become a problem on today's modern web. In May, [Google first rolled out a new "Perspectives" search filter](#) that would highlight posts from discussion boards like Reddit, Q&A sites like Quora and social media platforms in its search results. The feature, which first arrived on mobile,

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Google denies AI search features are killing website traffic

Sarah Perez - 12 hours ago

was [launched to desktop users earlier this month](#) along with other search changes.

The company [also said its ranking algorithm was being updated](#) to push more of these firsthand perspectives higher in search results so they're easier to find.

With the new tools, Google is giving websites hosting first-person perspectives the ability to signal to the search engine how their data is structured so their content will be featured both accurately and “as complete as possible” in Google’s Search Results, the company explains.

For example, with the new [ProfilePage markup](#), any site where creators post content will be able to showcase their creators’ profiles directly in Google Search results, including information like their name, handle, profile photo, follower count or the popularity of their content. Both Google’s Perspectives feature and its Discussions and Forums feature can make use of this type of markup.

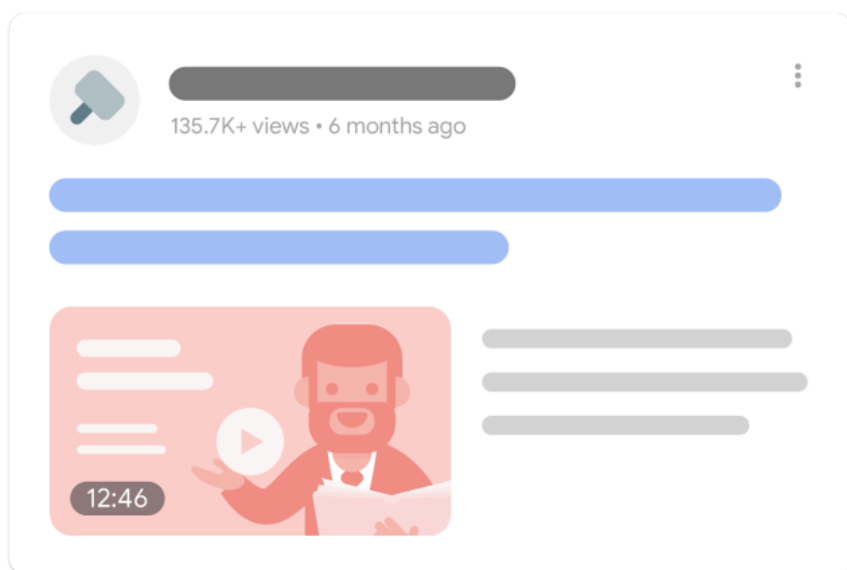


IMAGE CREDITS: GOOGLE

Meanwhile, the [DiscussionForumPosting markup](#) will help Google to better recognize the conversations that are coming from any online forum or discussion site around the web. While

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Google takes on ChatGPT’s Study Mode with new ‘Guided Learning’ tool in Gemini

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Google can already identify a number of top forums, like Reddit, in its Search Results, this markup would allow other, smaller sites to be better indexed, categorized and ranked by Google's new algorithm, as well.

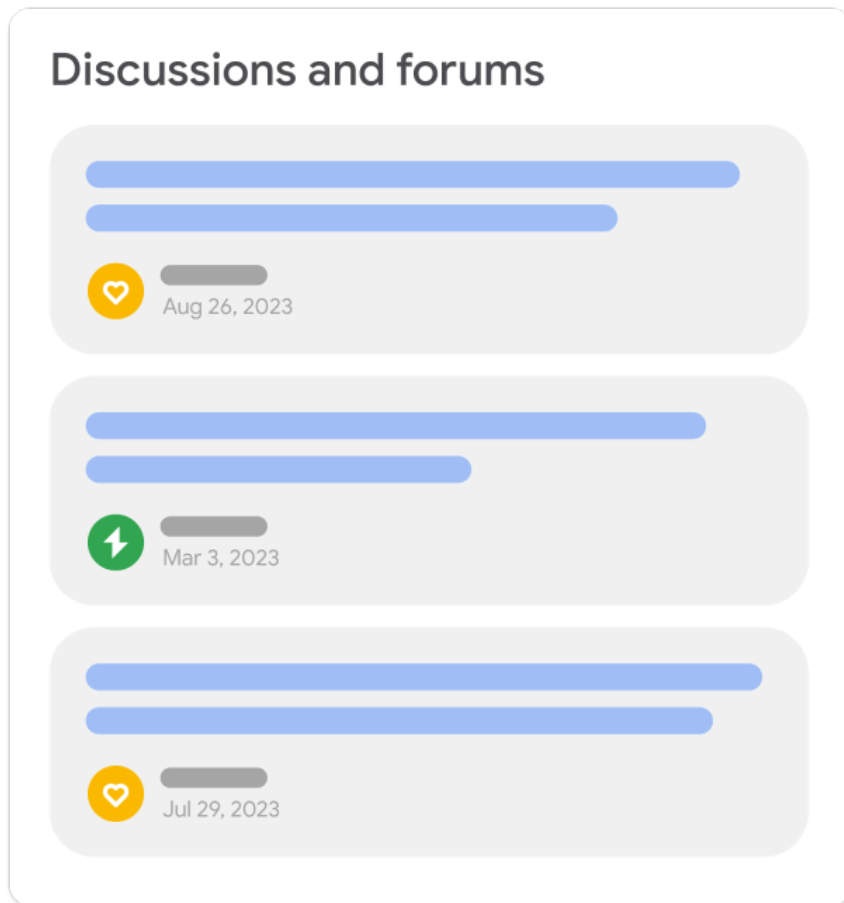


IMAGE CREDITS: GOOGLE

This includes Q&A sites, which have [their own markup](#), as well as [general discussion forums](#).

To support site owners in implementing these changes, Google is updating its Search Console with new reporting that will show things like errors, warnings and valid items related to their marked-up pages. Both features will also be available in the [Rich Results Test](#) so site owners can test and validate any markup changes.

TC

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Google's changes to how it categorizes and ranks content come at a time when there's a growing number of complaints about the search engine's usefulness.

Though Google arguably outperforms many of its search competitors, its results are now often littered with SEO-optimized, machine-written content, and there's a real fear that as AI advances take over, that problem will only get worse. Case in point: [this post circulating on X today](#) describes an "SEO heist" that stole 3.6 million in search traffic from a competitor by creating articles based on the competitor's sitemap using AI. While a horrible, worst-case scenario for AI (and an unverified one at that), it's creating a buzz because it exemplifies what many think will be the end of Google: faked, AI-written garbage prioritized over the work, thoughts, and opinions of real people.

We pulled off an SEO heist that stole 3.6M total traffic from a competitor.

We got 489,509 traffic in October alone.

Here's how we did it: pic.twitter.com/sTJ7xbRjrT

— Jake Ward (@jakezward) [November 24, 2023](#)

Whether or not this example becomes a reality — the proverbial canary in the coal mine — remains to be seen.

But this is precisely what Google’s ranking changes aim to address as the search engine attempts to better index, surface and categorize forums and social sites in search results.

Of course, Google’s experiments with next-generation search don’t end there. The company is also testing its own generative AI answer engine, Search Generative Experience, and [recently announced an experiment that will let users annotate web pages with notes](#) — likely, a hedge against Reddit choosing to lock down its site behind an API so as not be the source for AI training data without payment. If annotations took off, Google will have effectively built its own Reddit on Google directly, but the feature is still an opt-in experiment for now.

[Google overhauls Search with tools to follow interests, annotate web pages and more](#)

[Google overhauls Search with tools to follow interests, annotate web pages and more](#)

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